



ALMAU – TOLYQ ADAM 2026

THE UNIVERSITY OF THE FUTURE AS AN ENVIRONMENT FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF A WHOLE PERSON

The Heritage of the Great Steppe and Contemporary Solutions

30–31 October 2026 | Almaty Management University | Almaty, Kazakhstan

Dear Colleagues!

Almaty Management University invites you to participate in the AlmaU – TOLYQ ADAM 2026 International Conference, bringing together researchers, university leaders and experts around one of the key questions facing contemporary higher education: what kind of person should the university of the future seek to develop?

Universities are expected not only to respond to the current needs of society and the labour market, but also to anticipate what lies ahead. The rapid development of artificial intelligence, the transformation of professions and growing uncertainty are changing the very logic of preparing people for the future. Universities are educating students for a world whose contours are still taking shape: for professions that may not yet exist, technologies that will transform familiar ways of working and interacting, and challenges and decisions that cannot yet be fully anticipated.

For this reason, the focus can no longer be placed on professional preparation alone. Increasing importance must be given to qualities that retain their value regardless of how technologies and professions change: independent thinking, the capacity to learn and relearn, adaptability, agency, responsibility, ethical judgement and the ability to make decisions under conditions of uncertainty. In this context, the future of the university becomes inseparable from the question of the person: what kind of person should a university develop so that they are able not only to adapt to the future, but also to help shape it?

THE GREAT STEPPE: LOOKING TO THE PAST TO THINK ABOUT THE FUTURE

A distinctive feature of the Conference will be its engagement with the intellectual and cultural heritage of the Great Steppe as a source for rethinking the qualities people need today. For centuries, the Steppe shaped a particular social and cultural environment in which mobility required adaptability and independence, communal life called for responsibility and the ability to negotiate, and interaction among different peoples and cultures fostered openness and the capacity to act under conditions of uncertainty.

We propose approaching the heritage of the Great Steppe not simply as a subject of the past, but as an opportunity to reconsider fundamental questions about the person: agency, freedom and responsibility, relationships with the community, and the capacity to make decisions and take responsibility for their consequences.

The academic discussion will be opened by keynote speaker Professor Joo-Yup Lee, a scholar of the history of Central Eurasia and the Turko-Mongol world. The discussion will also feature Marie Favereau, author of *The Horde: How the Mongols Changed the World*; Catherine Poujol (INALCO, France); Peter Finke (University of Zurich); Zira Nauryzbai; Ainash Mustayapova; and other scholars of the history, culture and nomadic societies of Central Eurasia.

THE CENTRAL EVENT OF THE CONFERENCE: PRESENTING THE TOLYQ ADAM MODEL

At AlmaU, the idea of whole-person development has taken practical form in the TOLYQ ADAM educational model, implemented across the University since 2023. Its conceptual foundation draws on Abai's philosophy of harmony between mind, heart and will, reinterpreted in response to the challenges of contemporary higher education.

TOLYQ ADAM is an integral part of AlmaU's educational model and brings together a set of interconnected courses and practices designed to support students' development as whole persons. Its educational aims extend beyond professional competencies to include critical and creative thinking, the capacity for conscious choice and self-organization, emotional intelligence, communication, teamwork, social responsibility and a culture of service to society. The program includes Great Books, Philosophical Dialogue, Critical Thinking & Creative Writing, Service Learning, Life Design and other educational components.

In 2026, TOLYQ ADAM was named Winner of the "Teaching & Learning Strategy of the Year" category at the Times Higher Education (THE) Awards Asia 2026.

At the Conference, AlmaU will present TOLYQ ADAM to the academic community for the first time as a comprehensive educational model: its conceptual foundations, architecture, content and methodological approaches, together with the experience accumulated through its implementation and its results. This will open a professional discussion on how whole-person development can be systematically embedded in university education.

THE UNIVERSITY OF THE FUTURE: INTERNATIONAL EXPERIENCE

AlmaU's experience will be considered in the context of contemporary international university practices. Representatives of universities from different countries will share their approaches to developing human potential, including Liberal Arts, whole-person and holistic education, the development of critical and reflective thinking, research culture, values-based education and social responsibility.

Conference participants will have an opportunity to learn from the experience of The Education University of Hong Kong (EdUHK), Bard College, University of Zurich, Aix-Marseille Université, Deemed University (India), American University of Central Asia (AUCA), Nazarbayev University and other universities and educational organizations. The Conference program will also include guest lectures by leading scholars and practical workshops led by participating universities, offering a closer look at specific educational approaches, methodologies and tools.

AN INVITATION TO DIALOGUE

The Conference will bring together a contemporary reconsideration of the intellectual and cultural heritage of the Great Steppe, AlmaU's experience in implementing the TOLYQ ADAM educational model, and international approaches to whole-person development within the university environment.

We invite universities and research centres, government and international organizations, employers and experts who share the mission of developing human capital and are interested in exploring new approaches to the role of the university in developing the person of the future.

30–31 OCTOBER 2026 | ALMATY MANAGEMENT UNIVERSITY ALMATY | KAZAKHSTAN

**ALMAU – TOLYQ ADAM 2026
ORGANIZING COMMITTEE**

tolyqadam.almau.edu.kz

✉ **e-mail: icth@almau.edu.kz**

☎ **Tel: +7 747 467 09 75**